

Distributed Optimization for Machine Learning

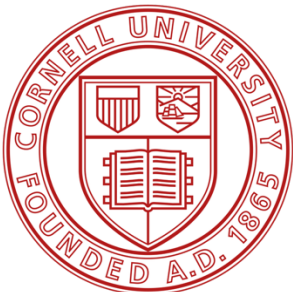
Lecture 21 – Analog computing for energy-efficient AI: Part I

ECE 5290/7290 & ORIE 5290

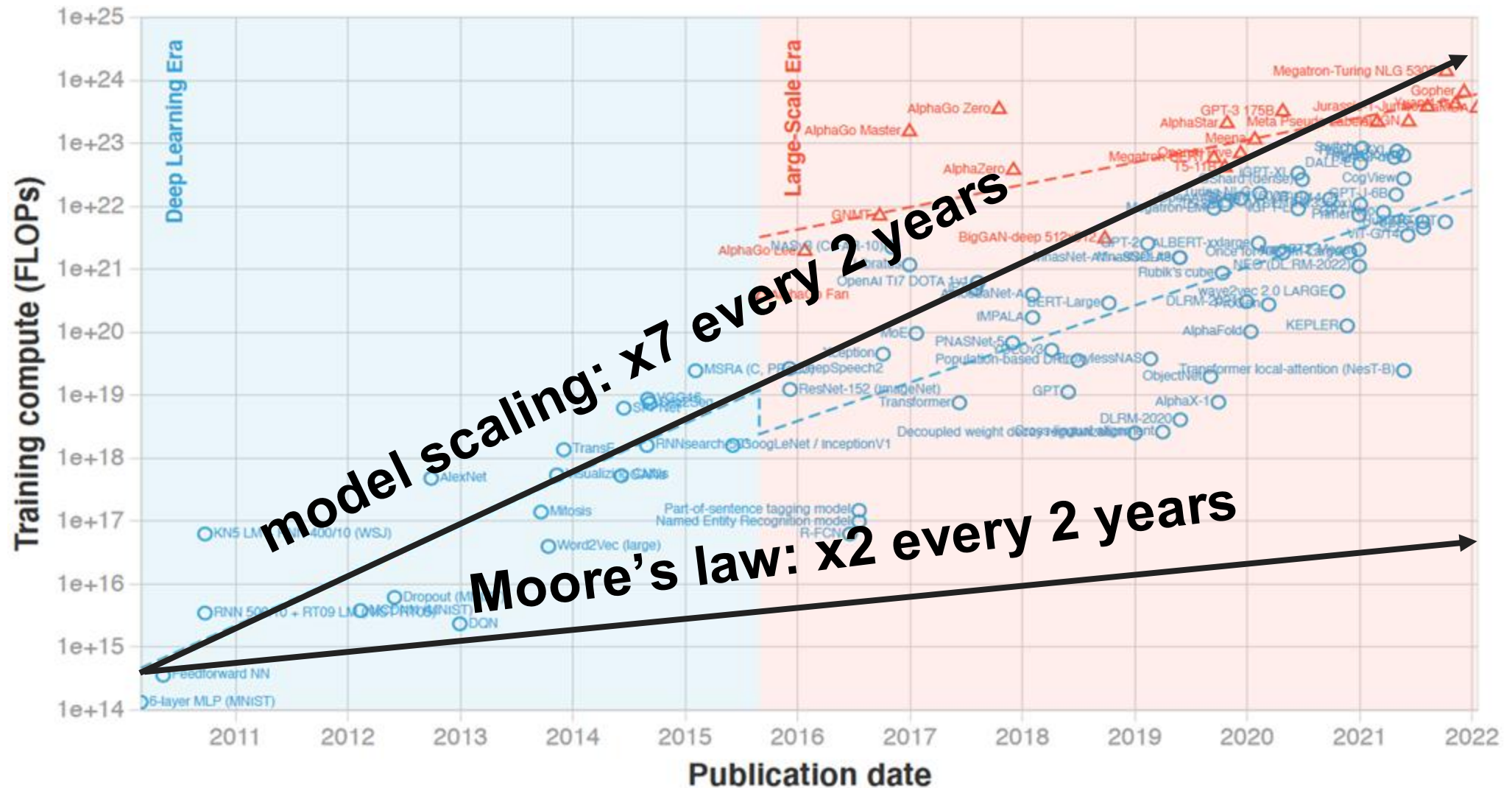
Tianyi Chen

School of Electrical and Computer Engineering
Cornell Tech, Cornell University

November 17, 2025



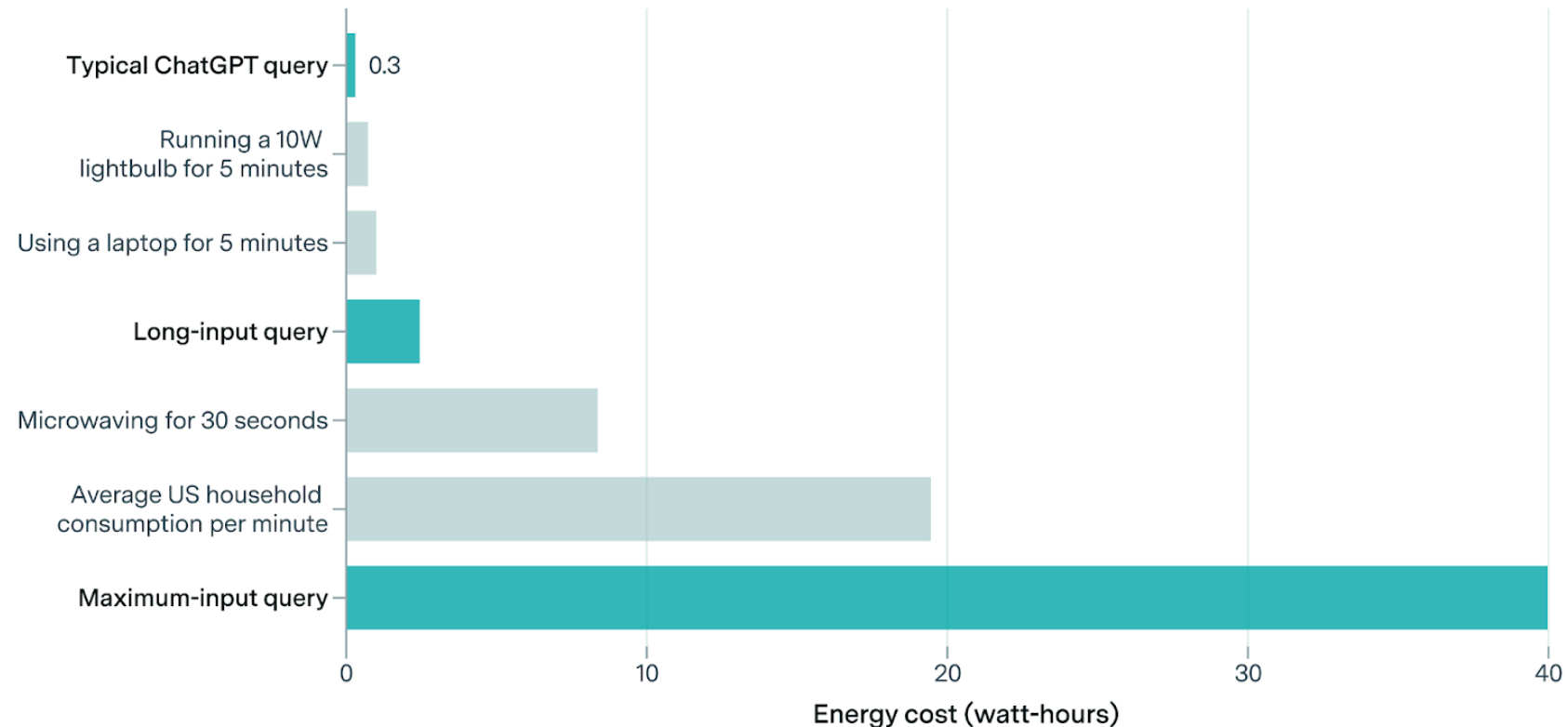
Training large models requires large compute



The carbon footprint of using ChatGPT

Energy consumption per ChatGPT query is small compared to everyday electricity use

≡ EPOCH AI



Pessimistic estimates of the energy usage of ChatGPT with GPT-4o across for different query lengths: typical (<100 words), long (~7,500 words), and maximum context length (~75,000 words), with an average response length of 400 words.

CC-BY

epoch.ai

Source: Josh You at Epoch AI (How much energy does ChatGPT use?)

Current computing hardware



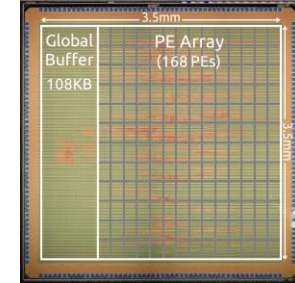
CPU



GPU



FPGA



ASIC

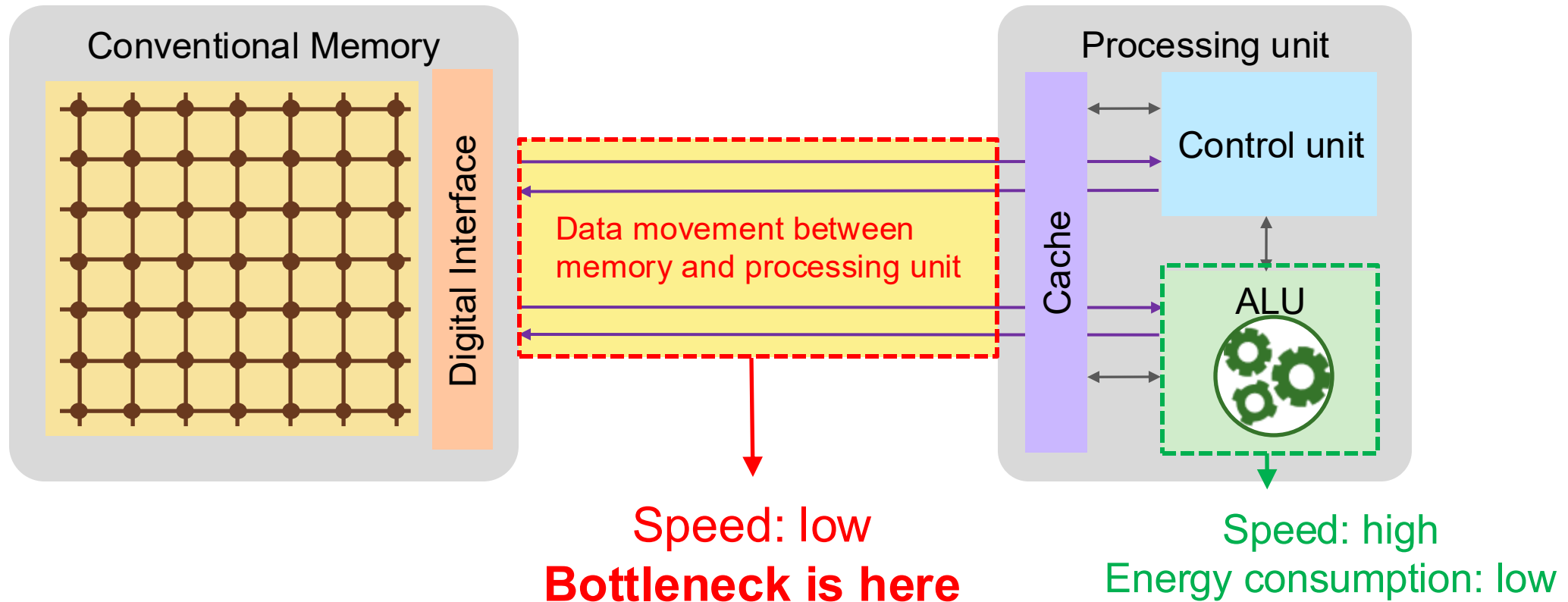


They all belong to **out-memory computation architecture**

<https://www.intel.com/content/www/us/en/newsroom/news/12th-gen-intel-core-i9-12900ks-worlds-fastest-desktop-processor.html#gs.9yghxm>
<https://www.nvidia.com/en-us/data-center/a100/>
<https://www.xilinx.com/products/boards-and-kits/1-t5lnks.html>

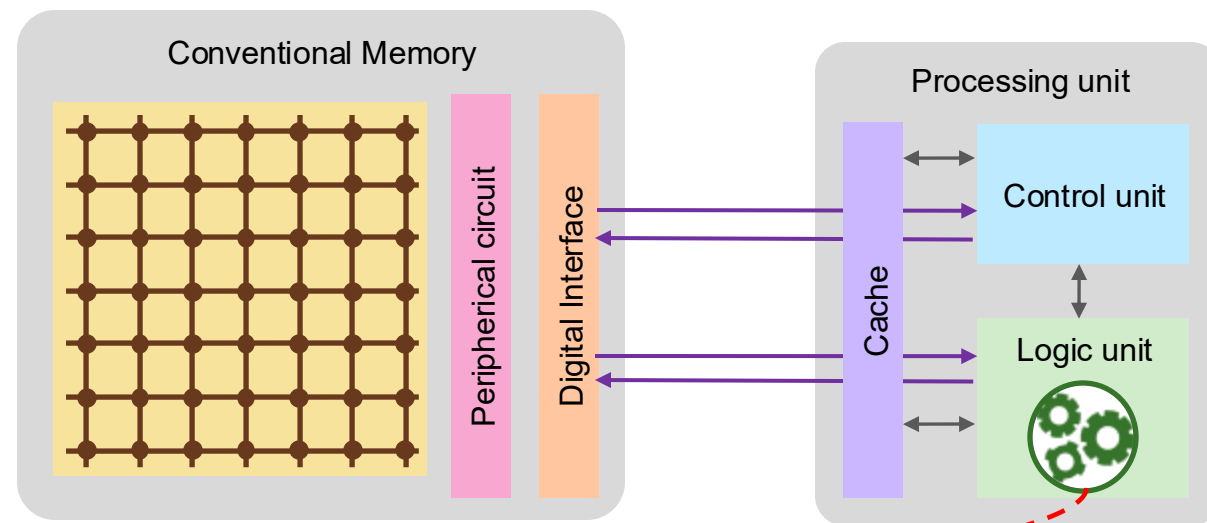
Bottleneck: Data movement is costly

Out-memory architecture



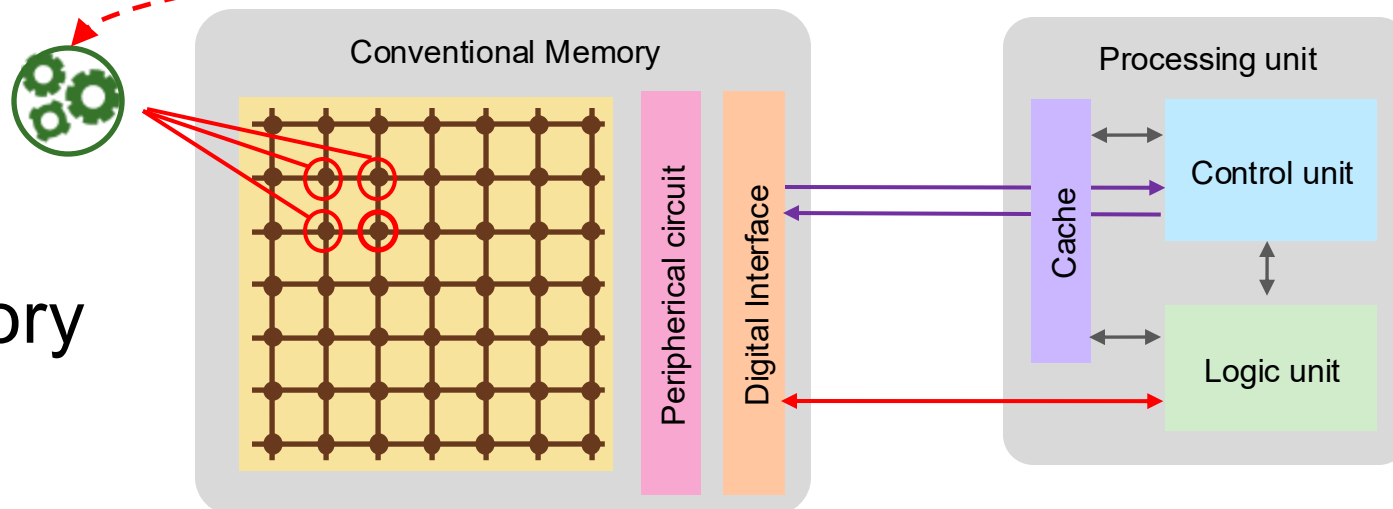
Out-memory vs in-memory computation

Out-memory

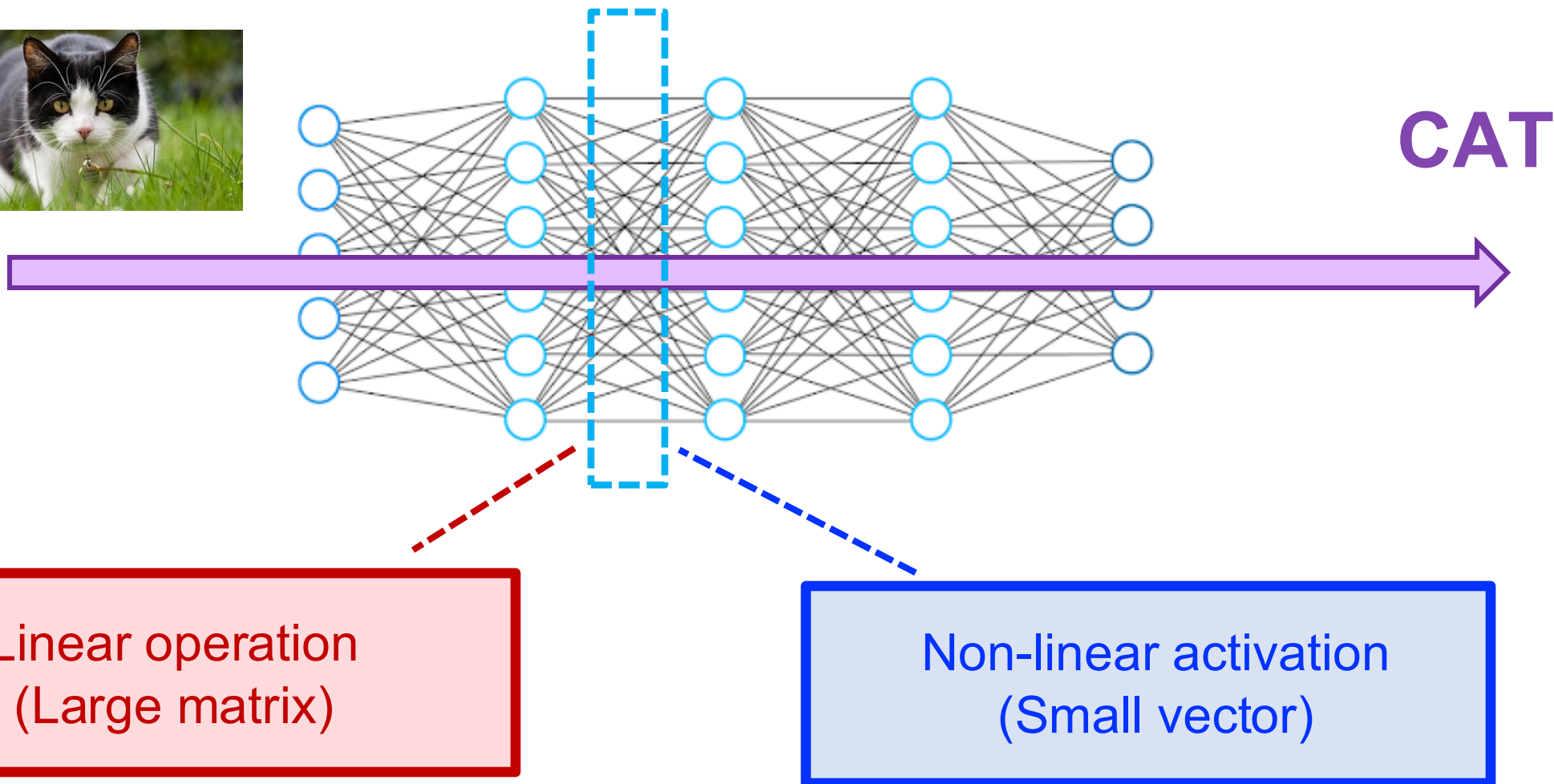


In-memory computation
can be done via either
digital or **analog** devices

In-memory



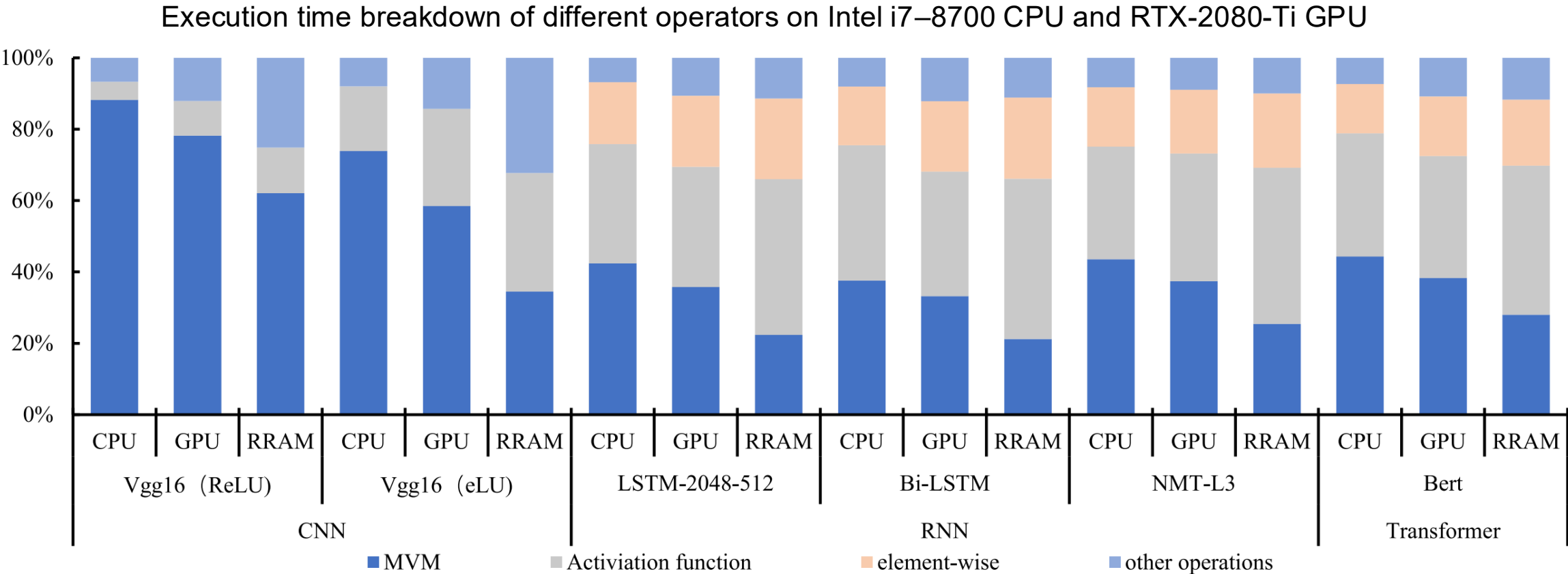
Data flow in deep models



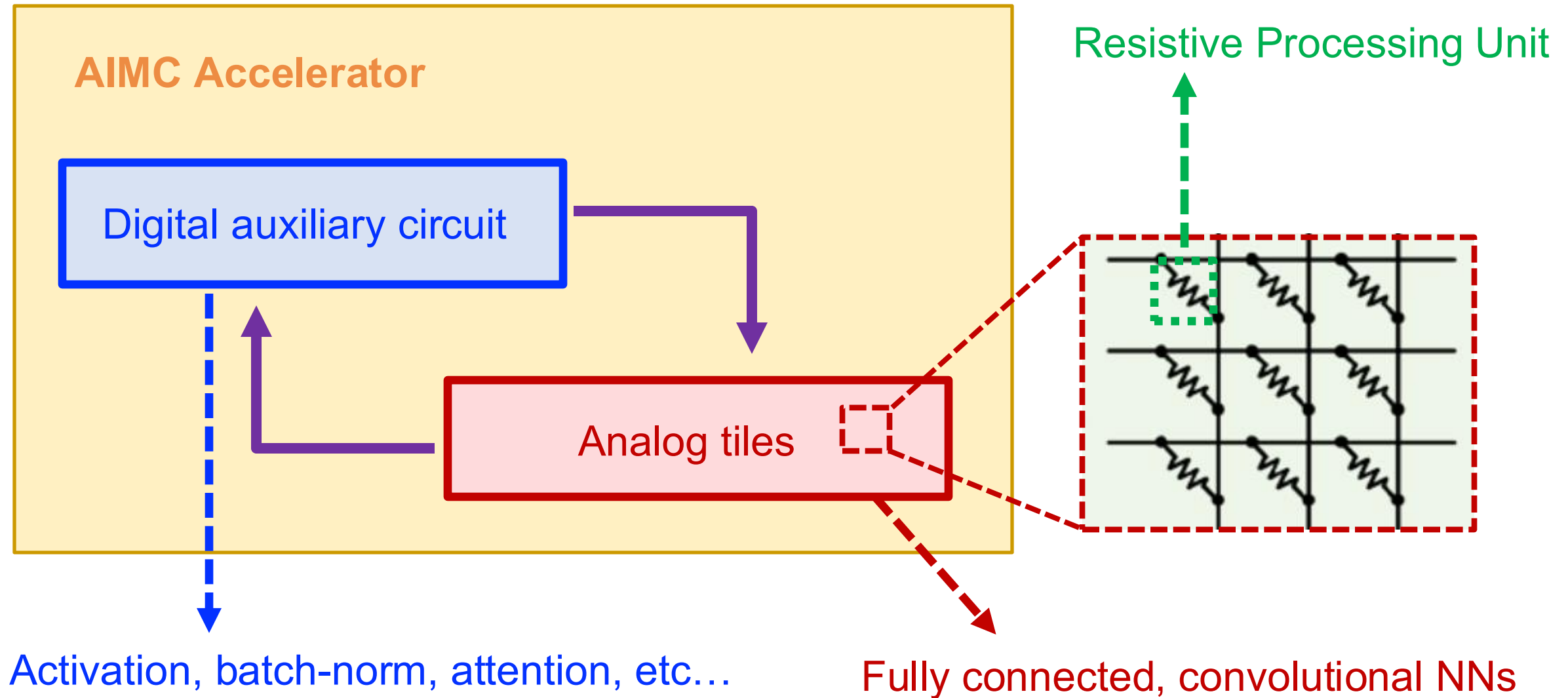
Fix computationally intensive layers in memory!

Motivation of analog in-memory computation (AIMC)

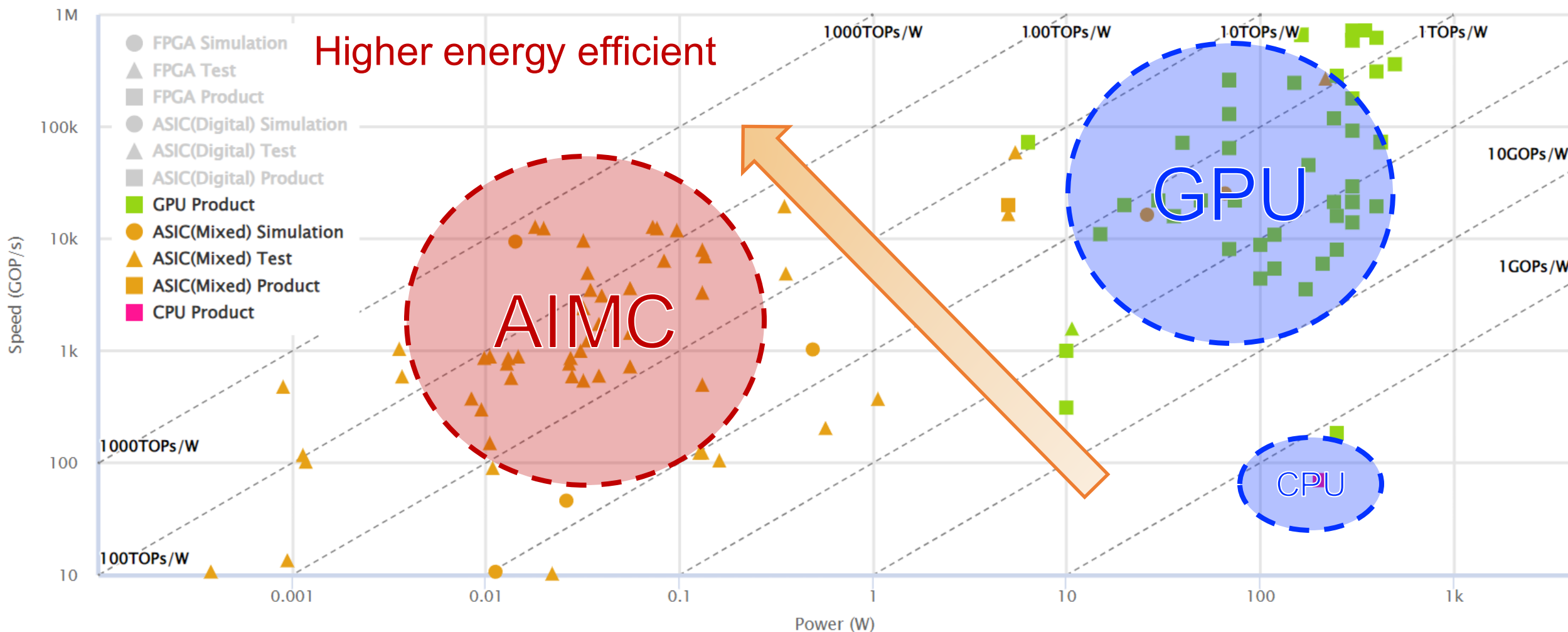
Matrix-Vector Multiplication (MVM) is the bottleneck of the DNN



Overview of AIMC hardware



Analog in-memory computing accelerates inference!



AIMC hardware: 10x-100x energy-efficient than GPU

Significant real impact on inference cost

GPT-4o

GPT-4o is our most advanced model. It's faster than GPT-4o Turbo with stronger visual knowledge cutoff.

[Learn about GPT-4o ↗](#)

Model

gpt-4o

gpt-4o-2024-05-13

Vision pricing calculator

Set width

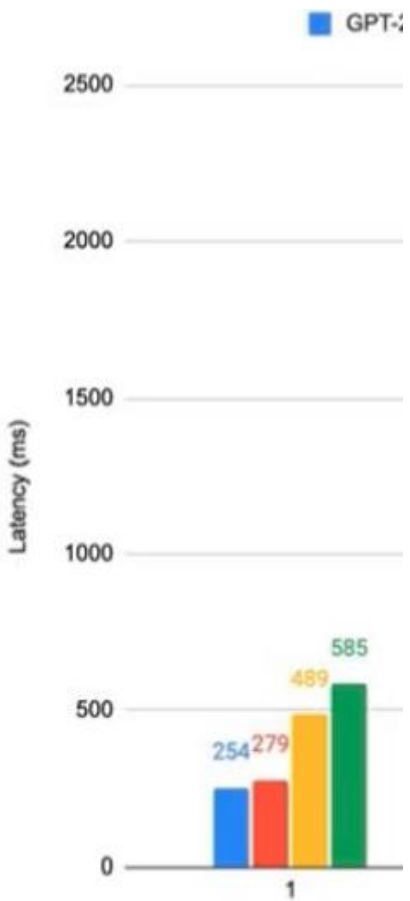
150

px

by

Set height

☐ Low resolution



Post



William Wang

@WilliamWangNLP



Just another day, waking up to find out that the undergrad hired by your grad student generated a \$20,000 OpenAI API bill in the last three days, without your authorization. 😅

10:42 AM · Jun 4, 2024 · **642.2K** Views



78

155

2.7K

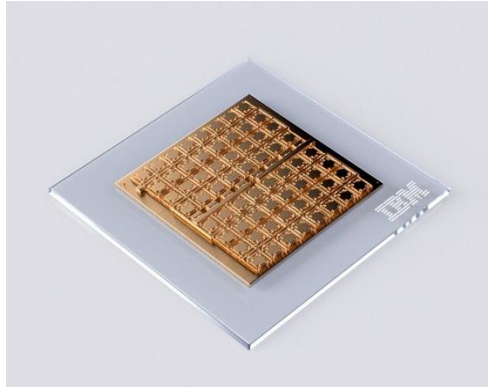
398



Post your reply

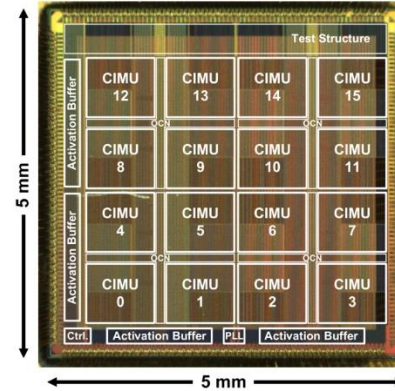
Reply

Recent AIMC chips



IBM

IBM HERMES chip
10.5 TOPS/W



EnCharge AI

Enlarge AI chip
30 TOPS/W



MYTHIC

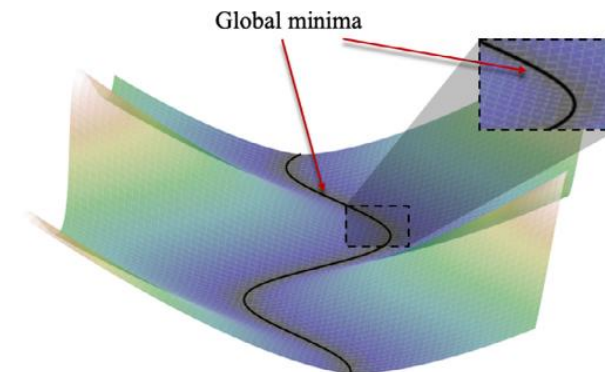
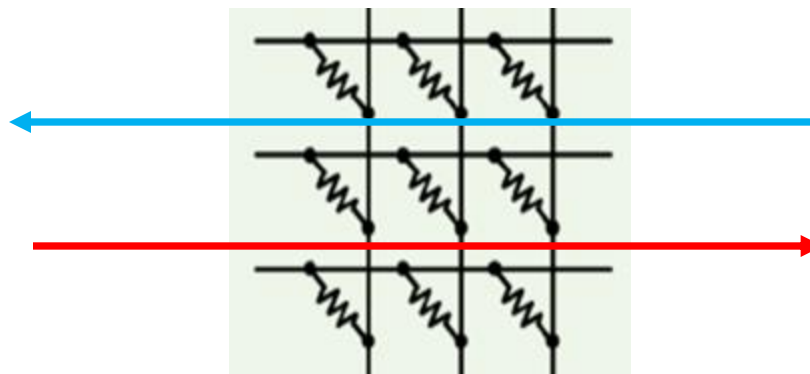
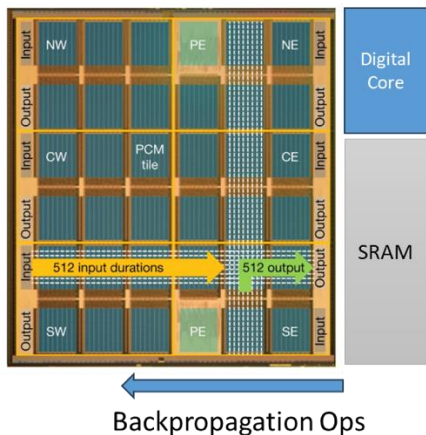
Mythic Analog Processor
6.3-8.3 TOPS/W

* TOPS/W = Tera Floating-point arithmetic Operations Per Second per Watt

M Le Gallo, et al. "A 64-core mixed-signal in-memory compute chip based on phase-change memory for deep neural network inference". **Nature Electronics** 6.9 (2023): 680-693.
H Jia, et al. "15.1 a programmable neural-network inference accelerator based on scalable in-memory computing." IEEE International Solid-State Circuits Conference. Vol. 64, 2021.
M1076 Analog Matrix Processor. <https://mythic.ai/products/m1076-analog-matrix-processor/>

Scope of this lecture

Hardware-aware SGD with built-in support



AIMC Circuit

Hardware property

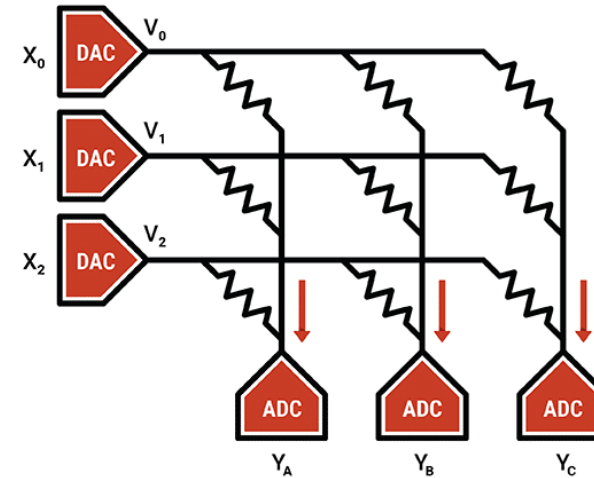
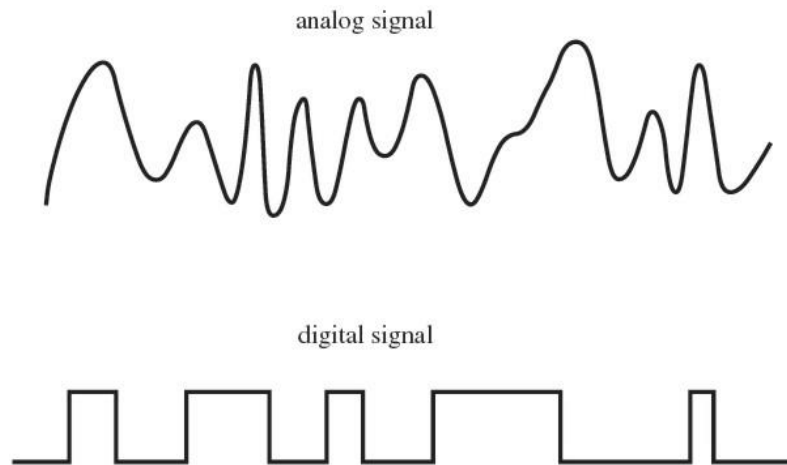
Analog AI

Hardware design

Algorithm design

Outline

- Background of Analog In-memory Computing
- Analog Inference: Hardware-aware Retraining



Resistive processing unit

Resistive processing unit (RPU): non-volatile electrical data storage unit

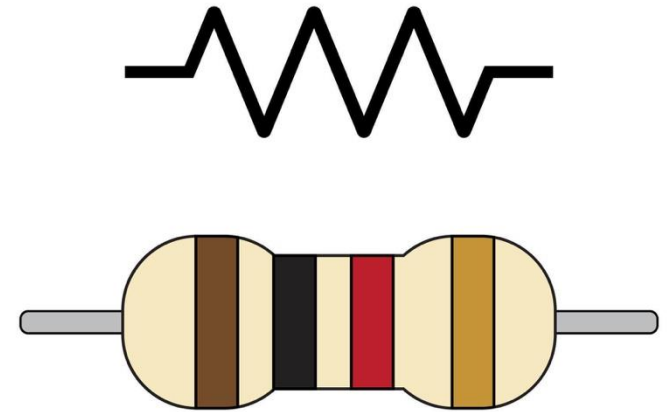
- Map the conductance (reciprocal of resistance) into the weight
- The weight in RPU is an analog quantity (continuous quantity)

Analog Representation

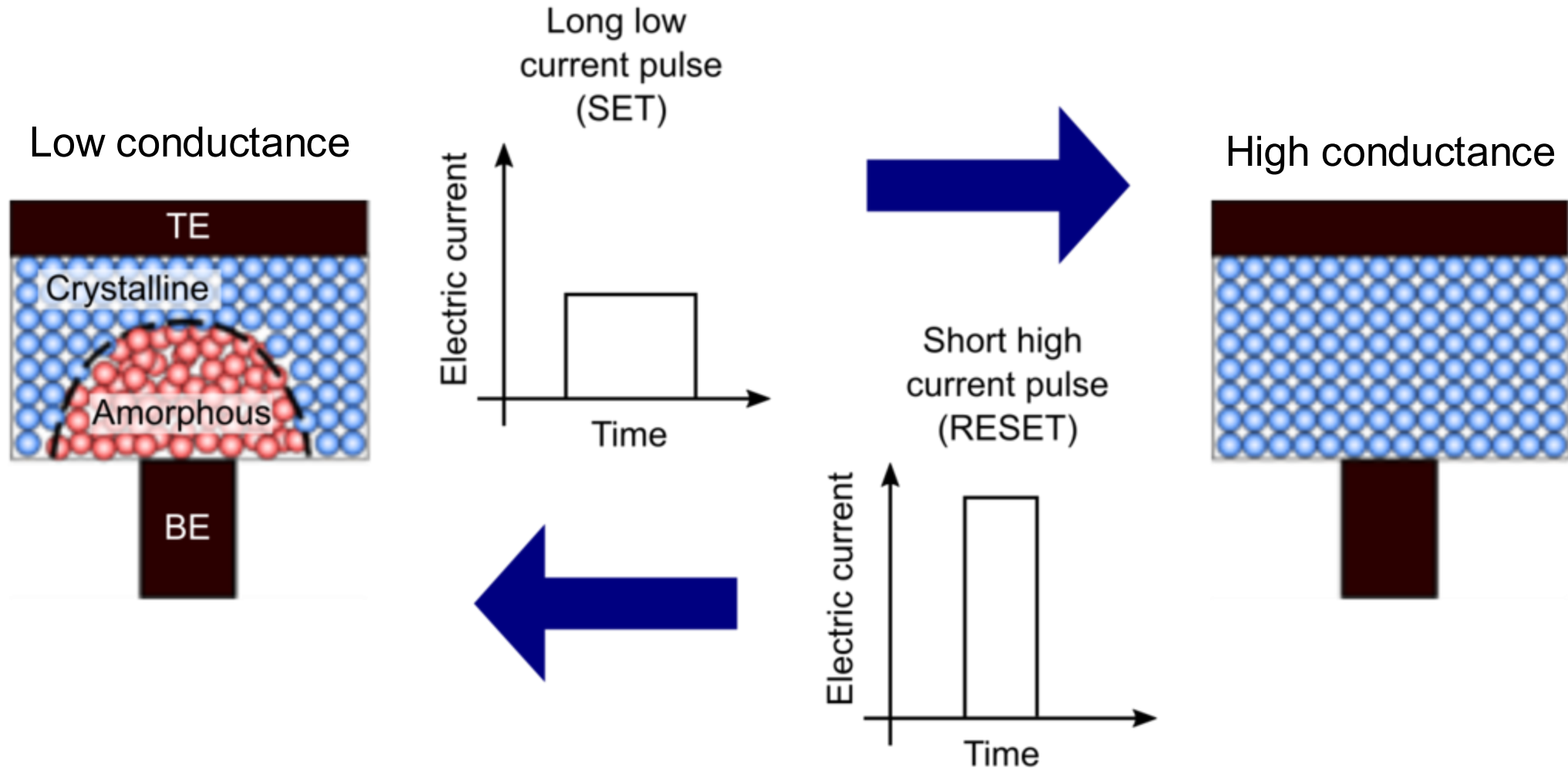
Conductance (nS)		Weight
10	->	0.1
20	->	0.2
30	->	0.3
40	->	0.4

Digital Representation

Code		Weight
001	->	0.1
010	->	0.2
011	->	0.3
100	->	0.4

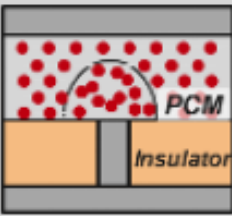
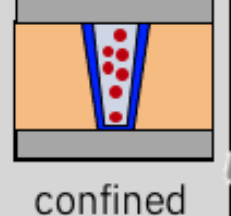
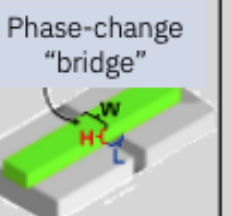
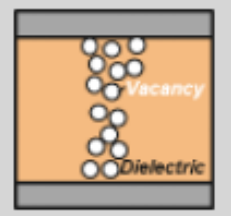
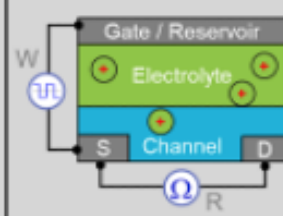
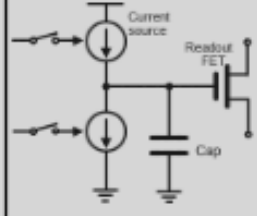
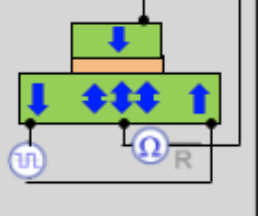
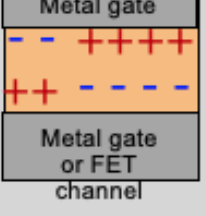
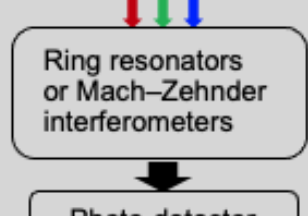


RPU example: Phase change memory



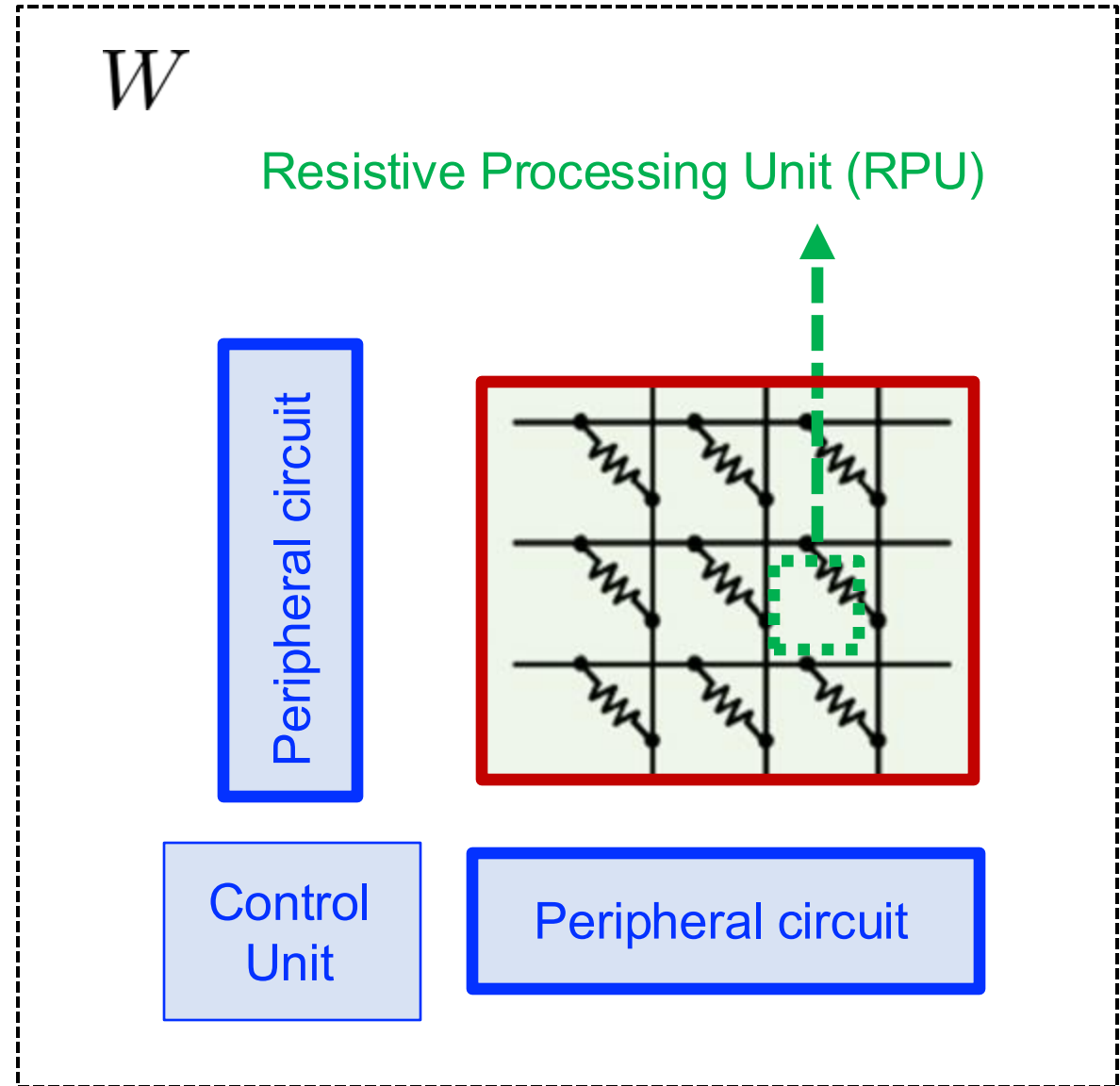
RPU can programmed by current pulses

RPU candidates

Phase change memory (PCM) (crystalline/amorphous transition)			RRAM (filamentary)	ECRAM (Electrochem)	CMOS (capacitor)	MRAM & Ferroelectric (domain wall motion)		Photonics (transmission)
 mushroom	 confined surfactant	 Phase-change "bridge"	 Vacancy Dielectric	 Gate / Reservoir Electrolyte Channel S D R	 Current source Readout FET Cap	 magnetic	 Metal gate Metal gate or FET channel FE	 Ring resonators or Mach-Zehnder interferometers Photo-detector
+ Mature among storage-class memory			+ Bi-directional + Small	+ Symmetric + Low power	+ Symmetric + Mature	+ Symmetric + Low power		+ Low power + Mature
- Abrupt reset - Asymmetry (1-cell) - Drift			- Stochastic - Asymmetry	- Open circuit voltage - Ion motion	- Cell size - Retention	- Domain wall control		- Cell size - Scalability (# of neurons)

Crossbar tile

- Arrange RPUs into a tile
- Peripheral circuits process the IO
(analog-digital conversion)
- One crossbar tile stores one matrix W



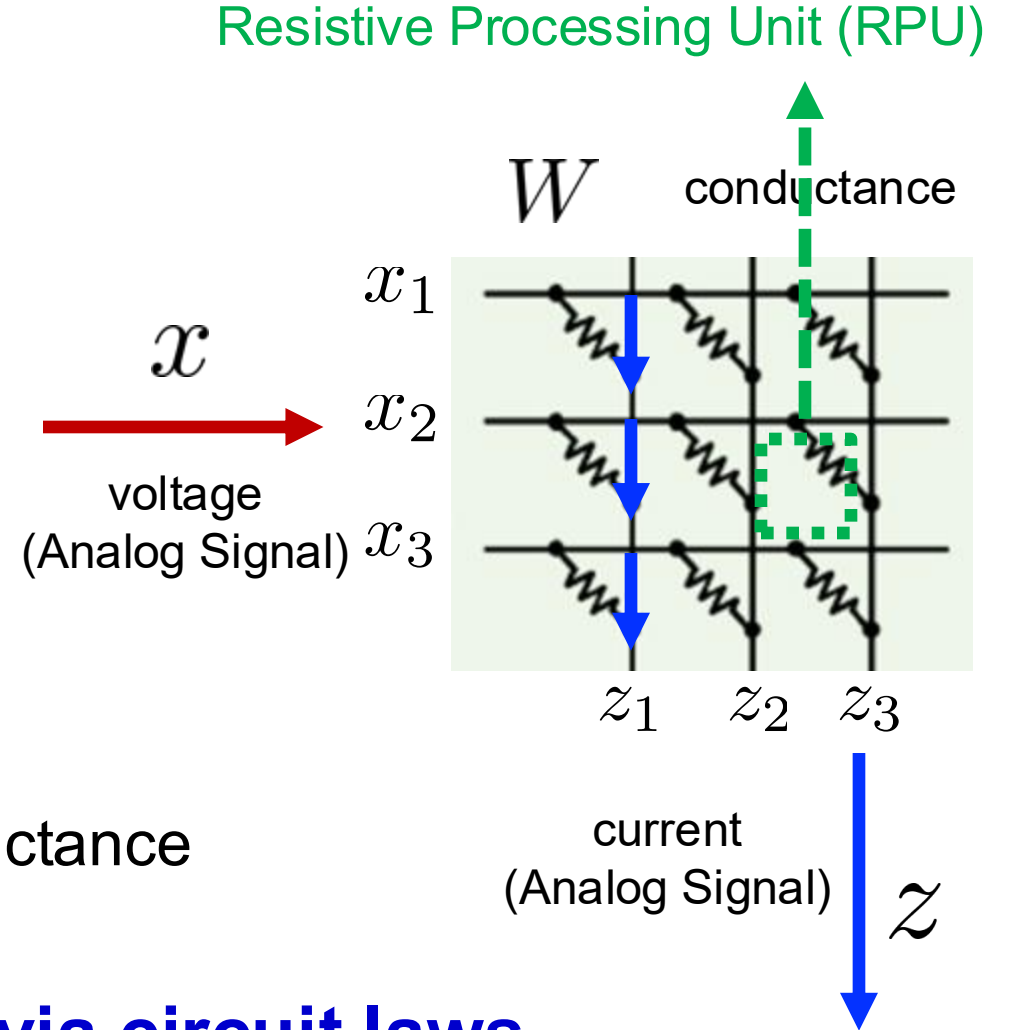
Circuit class 101: Ohm's law and Kirchhoff law

$$z = w \cdot x$$

↑ current ↓ conductance ↑ voltage

$$z_i = \underbrace{\sum_j \overbrace{W_{ij} x_j}^{\text{Ohm's law}}}_{\text{Kirchhoff's current law}}$$

- Basic circuit law: Ohm's and Kirchhoff's laws
- Data vector $\mathbf{x}$ is represented by the voltage
- Weight matrix $\mathbf{W}$ is represented by RPU's conductance



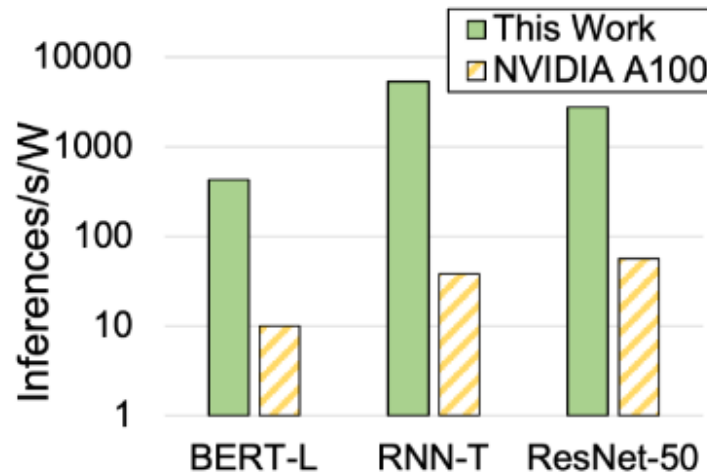
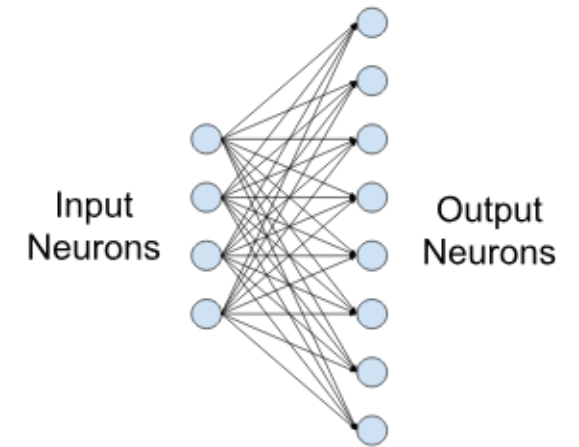
Matrix-vector multiplication done via circuit laws

Linear layers on RPU array

- Linear layer is implemented by directly computing

$$\text{Output} = \text{Weight} \times \text{Input} + \text{Bias}$$

- Save heavy multiply–accumulate (MAC) computation



	Digital	Analog
MAC	$O(N^2)$	$O(N)$

Compare with NVIDIA A100:

- 100x-300x MVM energy-efficiency
- 40x-140x overall energy-efficiency

Convolutional layers on RPU array

Convolutional layer:

flatten each convolution kernel to a row of matrix

flatten image patches into a vector

7	2	3	3	8
4	5	3	8	4
3	3	2	8	4
2	8	7	2	7
5	4	4	5	4

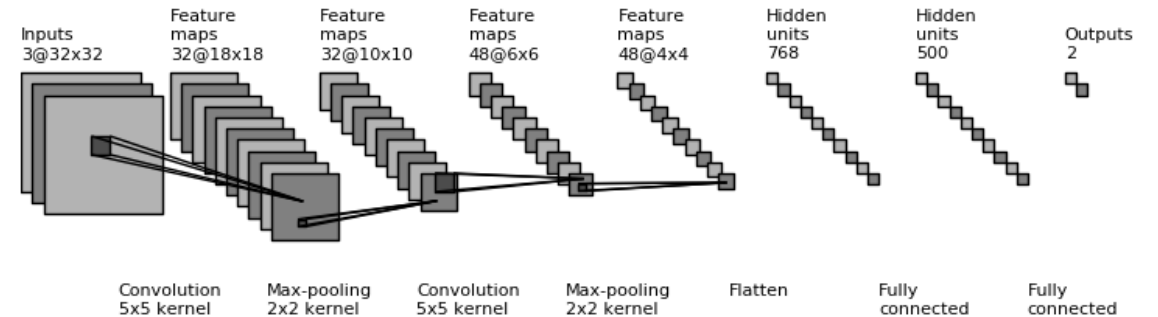
*

1	0	-1
1	0	-1
1	0	-1

=

6		

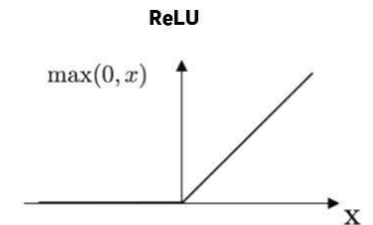
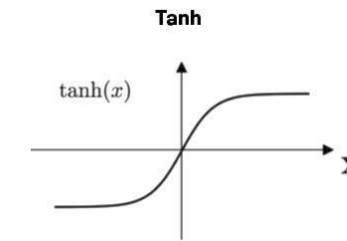
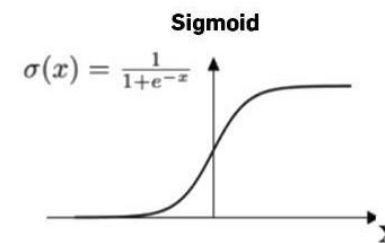
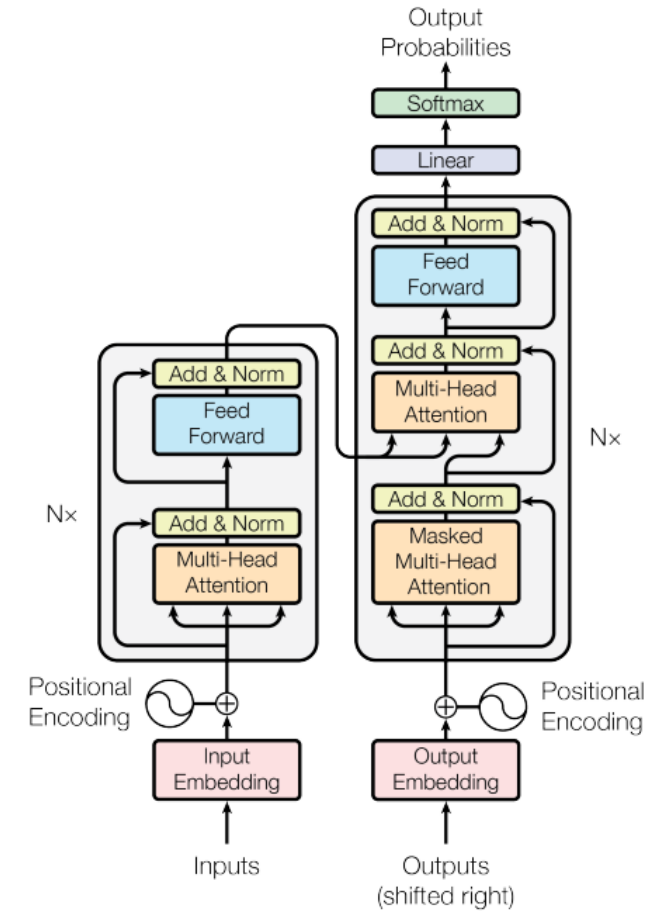
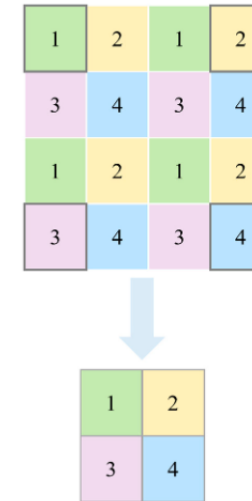
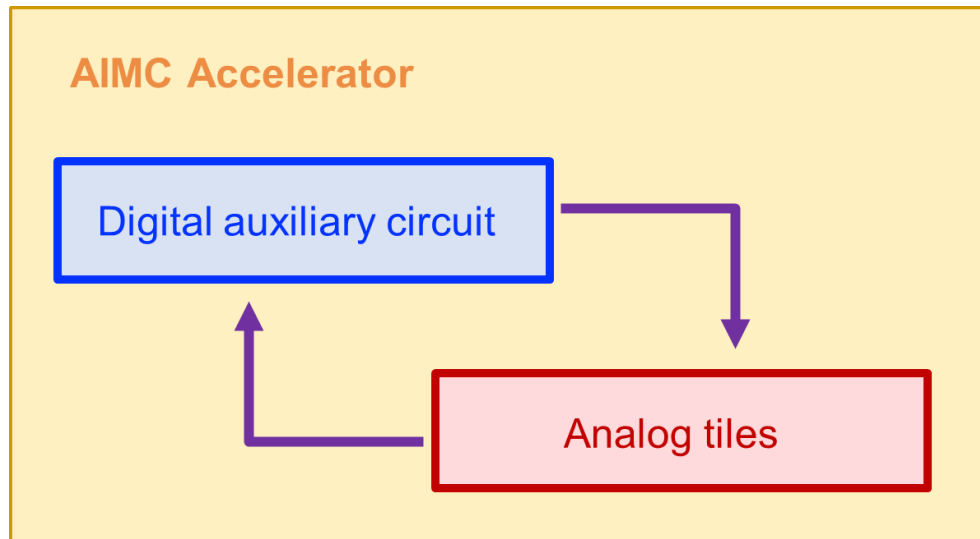
$7 \times 1 + 4 \times 1 + 3 \times 1 + 2 \times 0 + 5 \times 0 + 3 \times 0 + 3 \times -1 + 3 \times -1 + 2 \times -1 = 6$



Non-linear operator on AIMC hardware

Non-linear operations are carried out in digital domain

- Activation: Sigmoid, ReLU, LeakyReLU
- Down-sampling in CNN models
- Self-attention in Transform models

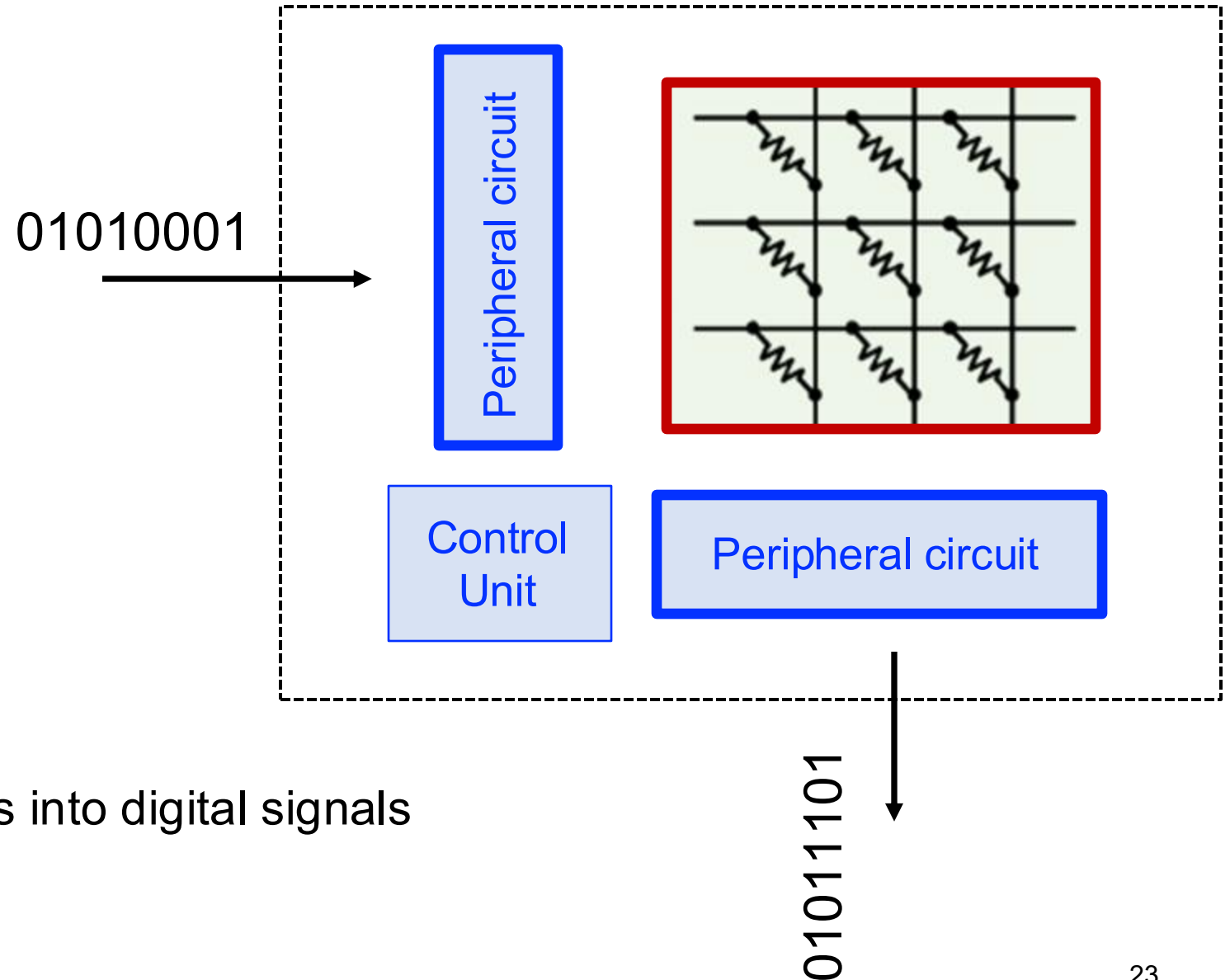


Analog-digital conversion

Peripheral circuit:

- Digital-Analog converter (DAC)
- Analog-Digital converter (ADC)

Quantize the current signals into digital signals



Weight programming

Pulse update: Send pulses to change conductance (thus weight)

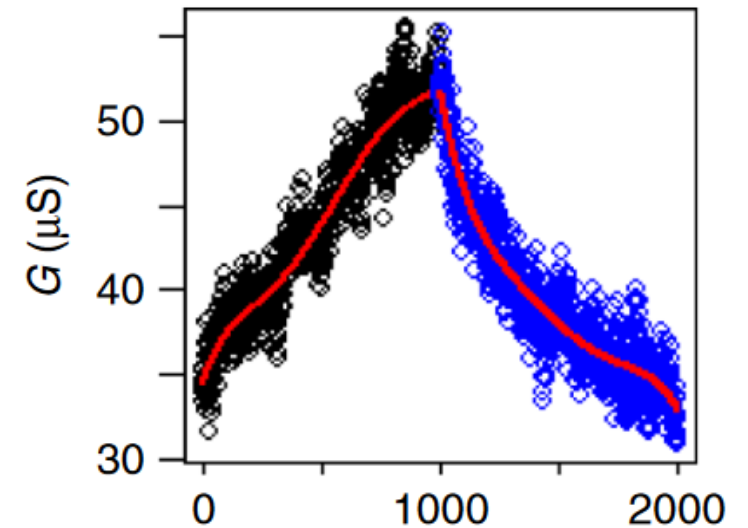
Program RPU for two purposes:

Inference: program pretrained model onto analog hardware

- Target weights are known

Training: keeping updating until model converge

- Target weights are unknown
- Adapt according to training objective



Different purposes leads to different update strategies

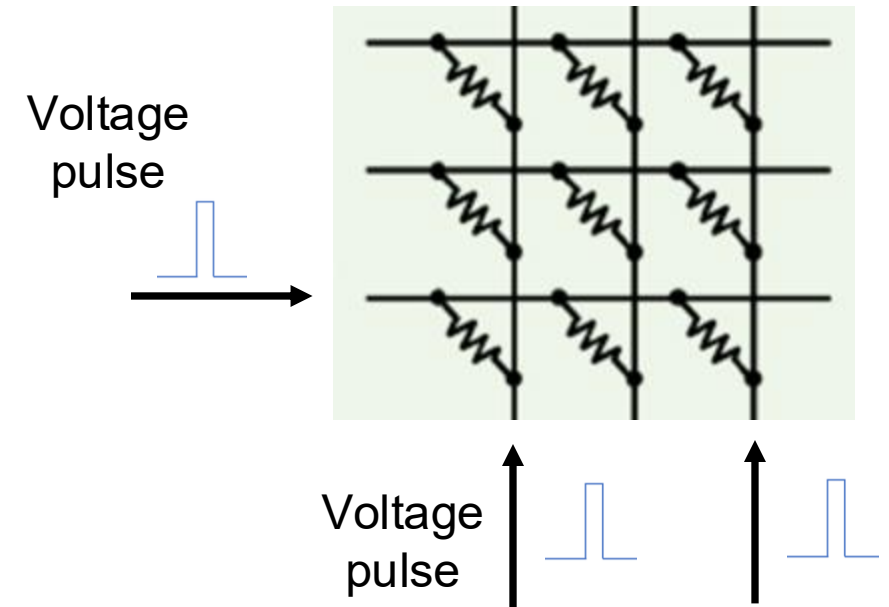
Weight programming for inference / training

Inference: expect to program the weights exactly

- Write-verification: ensure correct programming element-wise
- **More accurate** but **circuits become more complicated**

Training: only need to fulfill objective requirement

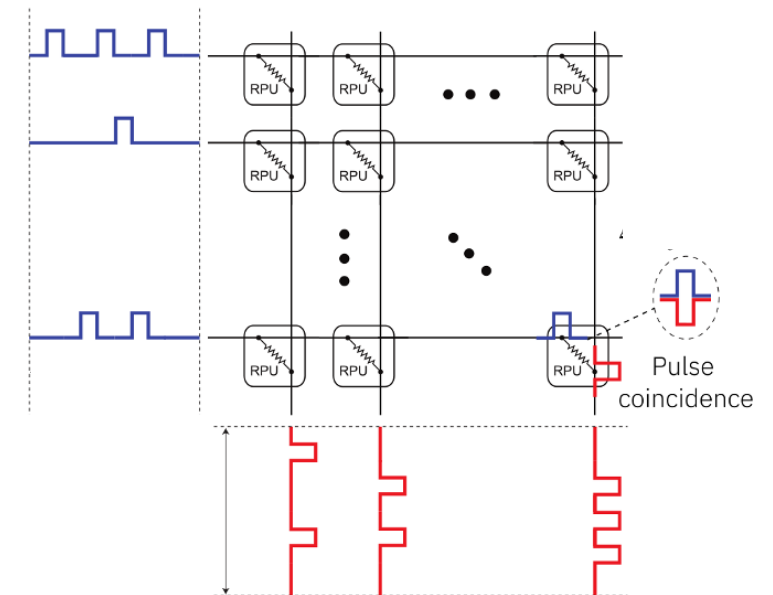
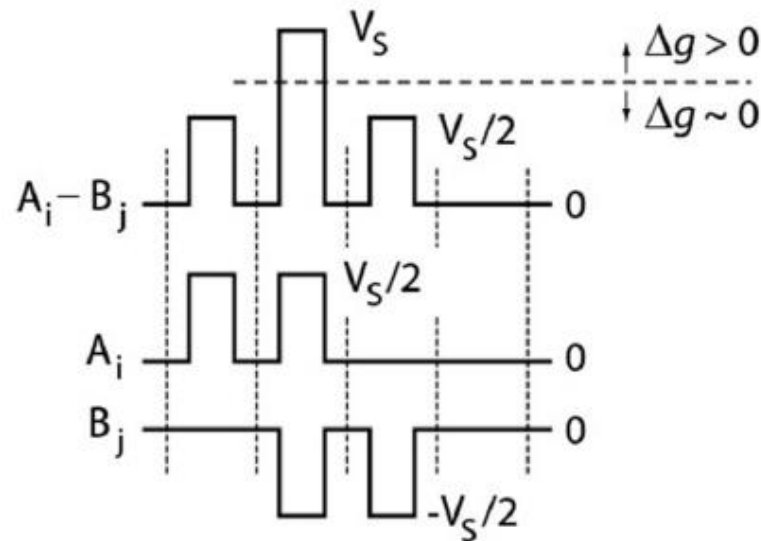
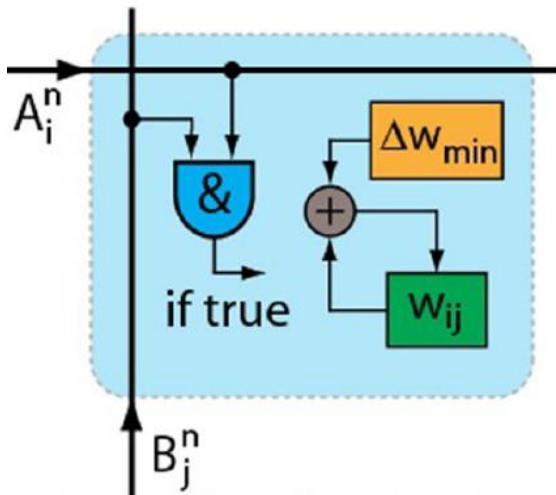
- Parallel update
- Idea: A pulse affects all elements simultaneously in the same row / column



Parallel weight programming

Parallel update in crossbar tiles:

- Send pulses to both column & row
- Pulse coincident incurs weight update



Weight copy

Direct copy:

Measure the conductance of each RPU

Parallel copy:

Taking MVM with one-hot vectors

$$\begin{bmatrix} a_{11} & a_{12} & a_{13} & a_{14} \\ a_{21} & a_{22} & a_{23} & a_{24} \\ a_{31} & a_{32} & a_{33} & a_{34} \\ a_{41} & a_{42} & a_{43} & a_{44} \end{bmatrix} \begin{bmatrix} 0 \\ 0 \\ 1 \\ 0 \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} 0 \cdot a_{11} + 0 \cdot a_{12} + 1 \cdot a_{13} + 0 \cdot a_{14} \\ 0 \cdot a_{21} + 0 \cdot a_{22} + 1 \cdot a_{23} + 0 \cdot a_{24} \\ 0 \cdot a_{31} + 0 \cdot a_{32} + 1 \cdot a_{33} + 0 \cdot a_{34} \\ 0 \cdot a_{41} + 0 \cdot a_{42} + 1 \cdot a_{43} + 0 \cdot a_{44} \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} 1 \cdot a_{13} \\ 1 \cdot a_{23} \\ 1 \cdot a_{33} \\ 1 \cdot a_{43} \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} a_{13} \\ a_{23} \\ a_{33} \\ a_{43} \end{bmatrix}$$

Parallel copy is more efficient if only a few columns are needed

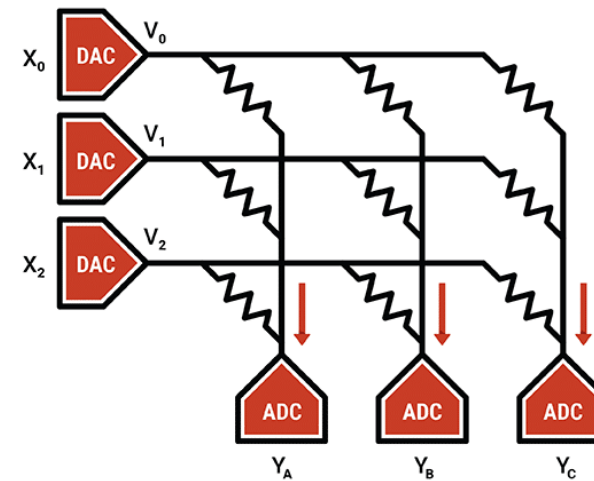
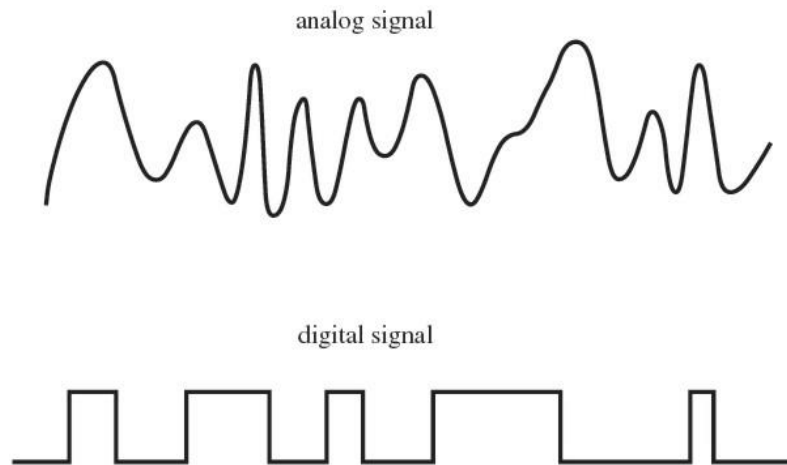
Takeaway

Basic operations on AIMC hardware:

- **Resistive processing unit (RPU)** leverages conductance to represent value
- **Matrix-vector multiplication (MVM):** Ohm's and Kirchhoff's laws
- Programming: **Pulse update**
 - Element-wise write & verification
 - Parallel programming
- Weight copy:
 - Measure conductance directly
 - Copying by MVM with one-hot vectors

Outline

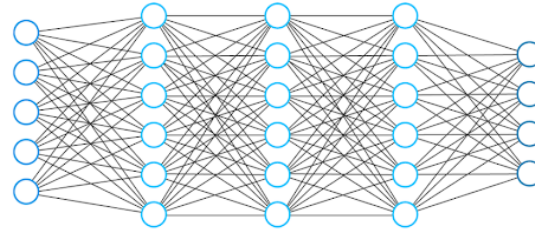
- Background of Analog In-memory Computing
- Analog Inference & Hardware-aware Retraining



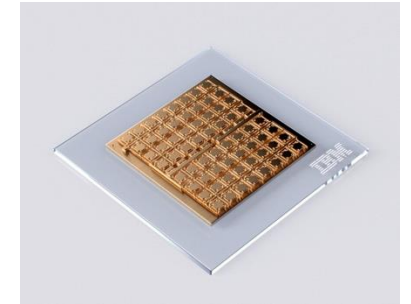
Inference on AIMC hardware



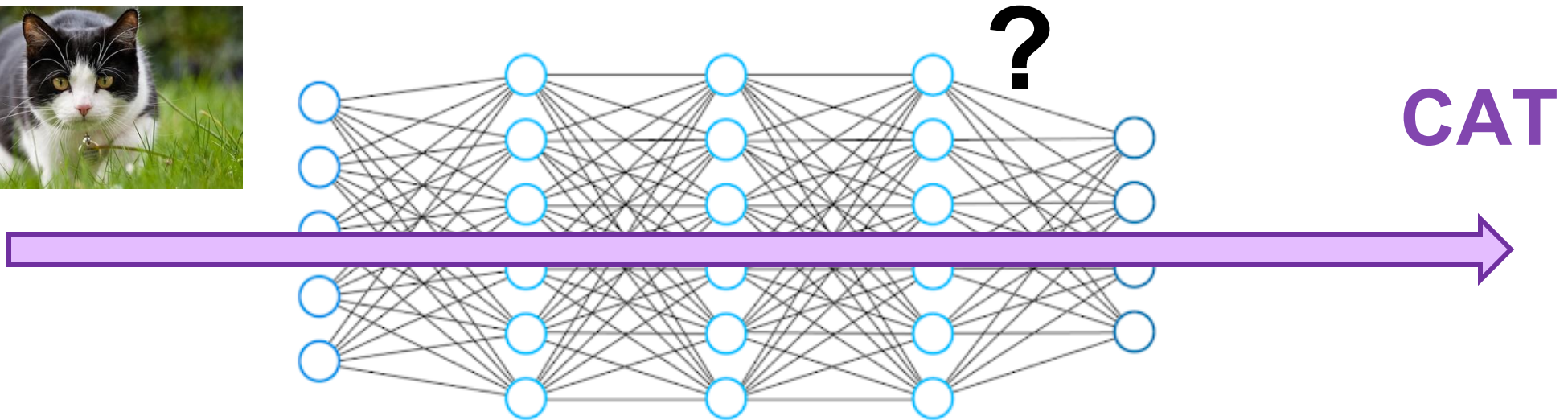
Pretrain a Model on GPUs



Pretrained Model



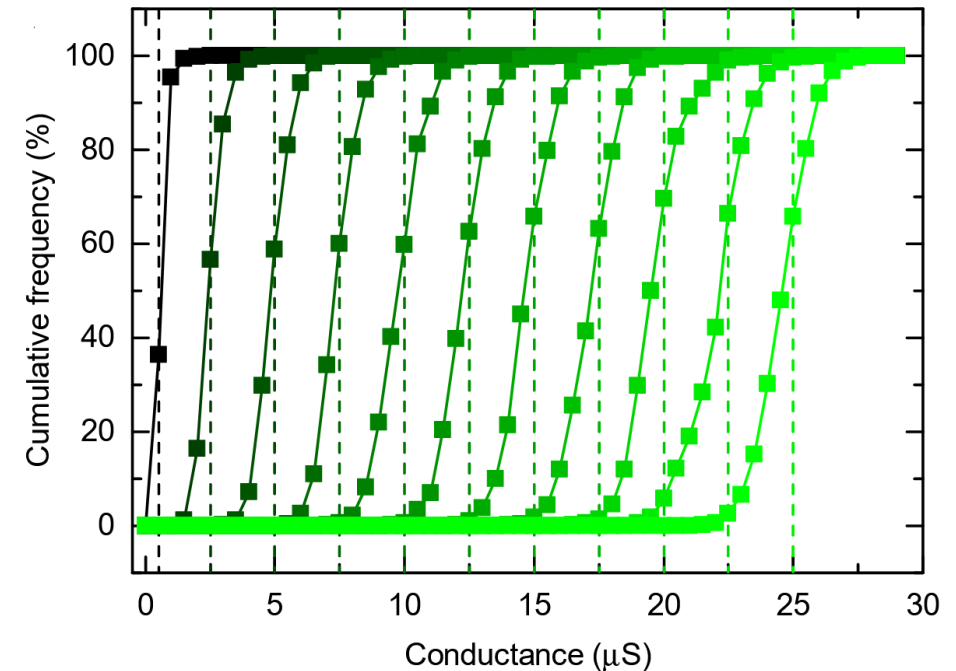
Program on AIMC hardware



Both programming and inference can be problematic

Hardware imperfection I: Programming error

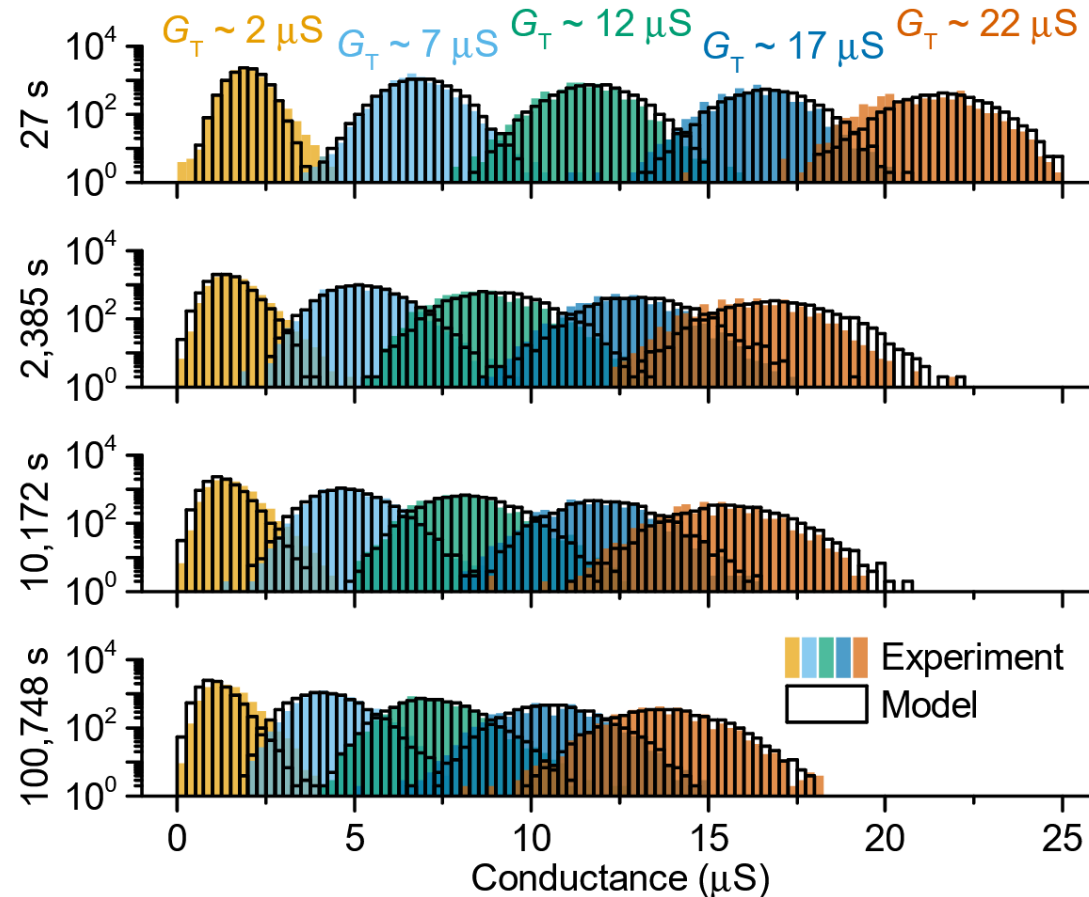
- The conductance values programmed on the hardware have a certain error
- Fig: Cumulative distributions of 11 representative iteratively programmed conductance levels



The programming processing is inaccurate

Hardware imperfection II: Weight drift

- Programmed weights drift over time
- PCM suffers from structural relaxation of the amorphous phase



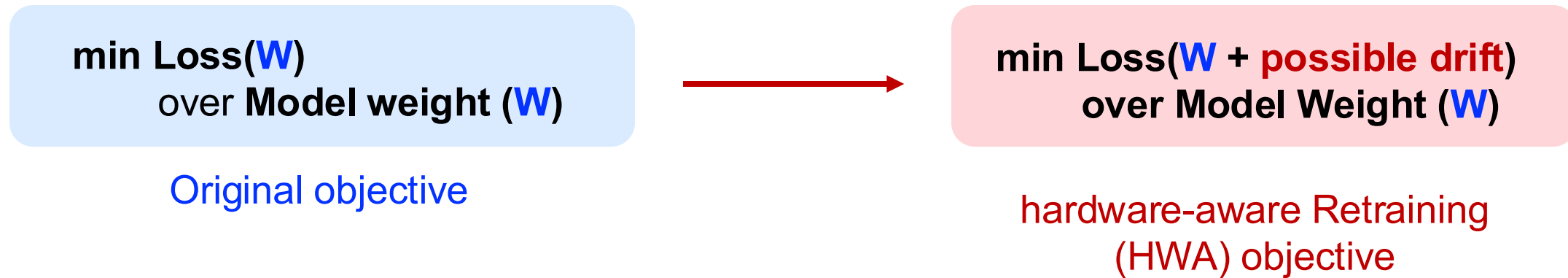
Hardware imperfection II: Weight drift (con't)

Direct mapping	Test Error in %		
	FP ₃₂	1 hour	1 year
ResNet-32 _{CF10}	5.80	11.68 _{0.16}	15.21 _{0.40}
WideRN-16 _{CF100}	20.00	26.02 _{0.10}	29.42 _{0.28}
ResNet-18 [†] _{ImNet}	30.50	47.91 _{0.21}	55.00 _{0.41}
ResNet-50 [†] _{ImNet}	23.87	32.51 _{0.09}	38.18 _{0.31}
DenseNet-121 [†] _{ImNet}	25.57	47.38 _{0.24}	59.81 _{0.71}
WideRN-50 [†] _{ImNet}	21.53	40.07 _{0.13}	45.45 _{0.30}
BERT-base _{MRPC}	14.60	15.99 _{0.23}	18.36 _{0.30}
Albert-base _{MRPC}	15.08	31.50 _{0.10}	31.62 _{0.03}
Speech [□] _{SWB300}	14.05	16.11 _{0.02}	16.32 _{0.02}
LSTM _{PTB}	72.90	73.16 _{0.01}	73.28 _{0.01}
RNN-T _{SWB300}	11.80	28.16 _{0.10}	29.08 _{0.16}

Weight drift incurs significant accuracy degradation

Analog hardware-aware retraining

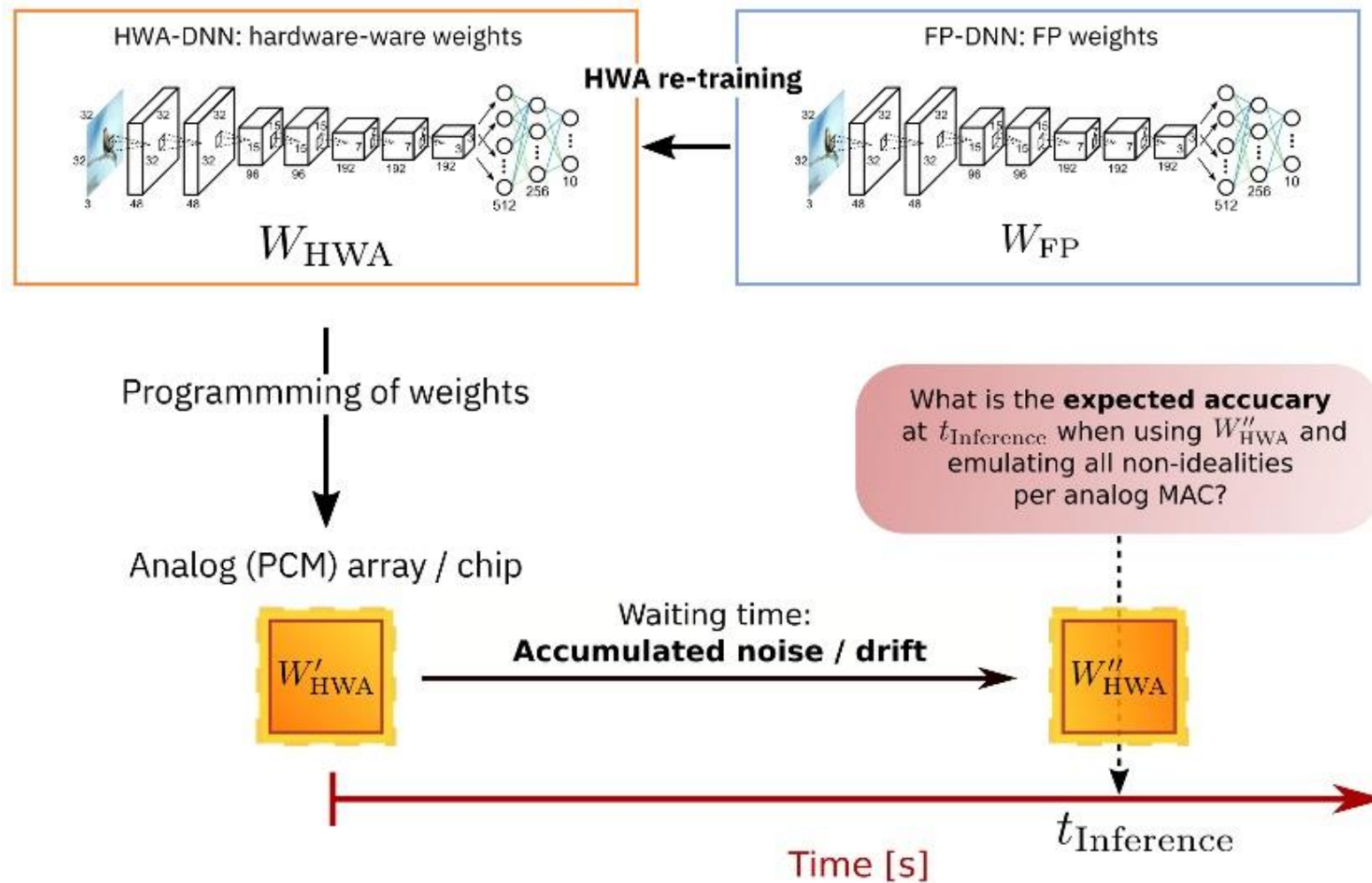
Idea: retrain with considering all the possible noise



V Joshi, et al. "Accurate deep neural network inference using computational phase-change memory." **Nature communications** 11.1 (2020): 2473.

MJ, Rasch, et al. "Hardware-aware training for large-scale and diverse deep learning inference workloads using in-memory computing-based accelerators." **Nature communications** 14.1 (2023): 5282.

Analog hardware-aware retraining (con't)



V Joshi, et al. "Accurate deep neural network inference using computational phase-change memory." **Nature communications** 11.1 (2020): 2473.

MJ, Rasch, et al. "Hardware-aware training for large-scale and diverse deep learning inference workloads using in-memory computing-based accelerators." **Nature communications** 14.1 (2023): 5282.

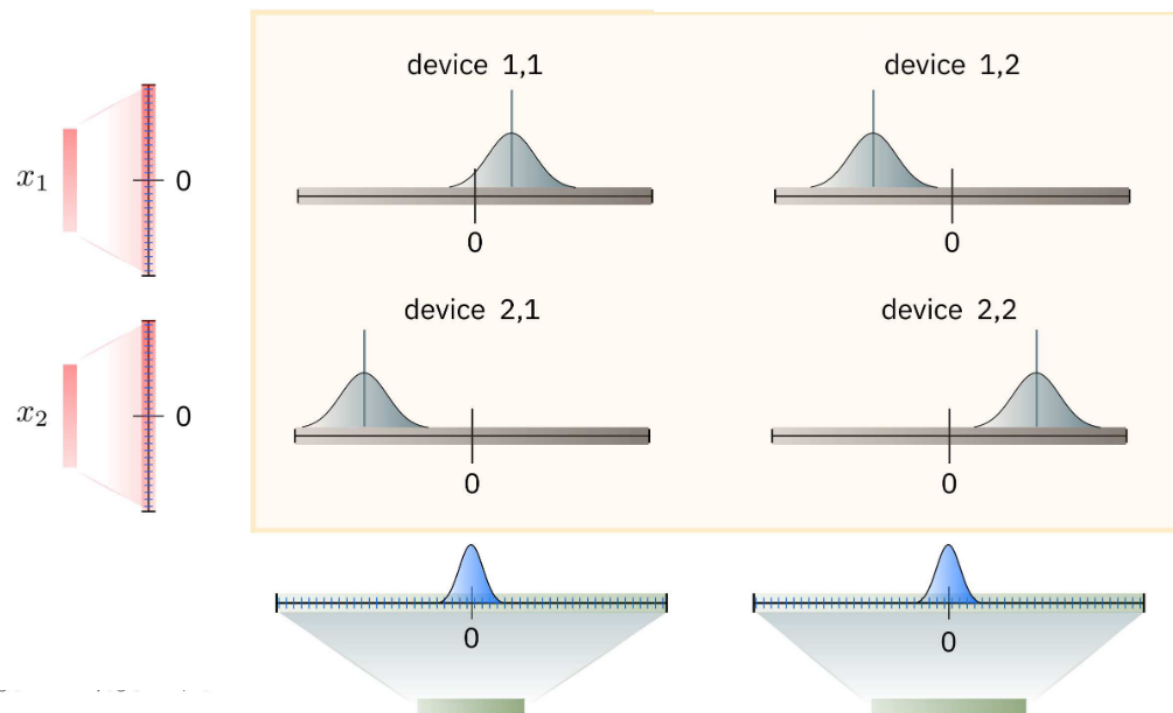
Hardware imperfection III: Quantization & read noise

- Weights suffers from instantaneous fluctuations due to the intrinsic noise

$$\text{Output} = \text{Quad} ((\text{Weight} + \text{noise}) \times \text{Input} + \text{Bias})$$

Similar signals are quantized to same level

$$z = \text{Quad}((W + \varepsilon)x)$$



Hardware imperfection III: Quantization & read noise

- Solution: scale the input before MVM

$$\tilde{x} = \frac{x}{\alpha} \quad \tilde{z} = \text{Quad}((W + \varepsilon)\tilde{x}) \quad z = \alpha\tilde{z}$$

- Equivalently

$$z = \alpha \cdot \text{Quad}\left((W + \epsilon) \cdot \frac{x}{\alpha}\right)$$

